A DOCTORAL THESIS

OCTOBER 2026



THE LAND OF REMORSE

Natal Vengeance, Tarantic Rite, and the Unfinished Humanism of Quentin Tarantino's Kill Bill



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Abstract

This dissertation contends that Quentin Tarantino's *Kill Bill*, read as a single work in ten chapters across *Vol. 1* (2003) and *Vol. 2* (2004), is adequately described neither as the "blank parody" of postmodern pastiche, nor as a postfeminist fantasy of individualized empowerment, nor as an Orientalist bricolage of East Asian genre cinema, the three paradigms that have governed its reception. It is, rather, a *tarantic rite of natal vengeance*: a cinematic liturgy in which a woman whose presence has been annulled by sovereign-patriarchal violence re-enacts the originary wound through ritually coded violence (genre citation, musical cue, chromatic rupture, choreographed combat) until the bloody, law-making violence of the talion exhausts itself in a bloodless violence undertaken, in Walter Benjamin's phrase, for the sake of the living.

The study proceeds by philosophical film criticism and comparative intellectual history. It reconstructs two genealogies: a documented cinematic-literary lineage (Koike, Kamimura and Fujita's *Lady Snowblood*; *Lone Wolf and Cub*; the Shaw Brothers and Lau Kar-leung; Fukasaku; Woolrich and Truffaut; Ford and Leone; Swedish exploitation cinema) and a mediated philosophical lineage (Linji Yixuan, Yagyū Munenori, Xunzi, Mencius, Confucius, Aeschylus, Seneca, Bacon, Kant, Hegel, Nietzsche, Benjamin, Arendt). It then sets the film against canonical works of feminism (Wollstonecraft, Woolf, Beauvoir, Mulvey, Rubin, Lorde, Clover, Butler, hooks, Ruddick, Cixous, Kristeva) and of humanism (Pico della Mirandola, Montaigne, Kant, Sartre, Fanon, Said, Todorov).

Five arguments result. First, the film stages the juridical passage from collective feud to individual retribution, then re-founds the feud through what I name the *Nikki Bell Principle*: every vengeance that orphans a child bequeaths a vendetta. Second, its non-linear form constitutes an ethics of time, a technique for the will's revolt against the irreversible "it was." Third, its violence passes *from blade to palm*, from mythic to divine violence, a passage encoded even in the herpetology of its codenames. Fourth, Bill's "Superman doctrine" of innate killerhood is refuted less by its feminist antithesis (one becomes) than by the film's image of the subject as *beginning*. Fifth, the film distributes death unequally along lines of race and maternity, and its closing intertitle relapses into zoological essentialism.

Synthesizing Ernesto de Martino's anthropology of Apulian tarantism with Hannah Arendt's theory of natality, the dissertation proposes *natal humanism*, a humanism grounded not in what the human is but in the fact that humans are born and can begin, and reads *Kill Bill*'s feminism as a *feminism of the second birth*:

formidable, compromised, and constitutively unfinished. The film ends not in justice but in the land of remorse, where the bite returns.

INTRODUCTION



The Imperative and the Invoice

The title of Kill Bill *is a command, and the argument of this dissertation begins from the consequences of that grammatical fact.*

SECTIONS

A Title in the Imperative Mood
The Polysemy of a Name
The State of the Question
Method
Thesis
Architecture
Note on Texts

A *Title in the Imperative Mood*

Few titles in the history of narrative cinema are commands. *Kill Bill* is an imperative without a grammatical subject, addressed simultaneously to its heroine, to its spectator, and to the film itself, and it discloses its telos before its first image. In J. L. Austin's vocabulary it belongs less to the order of constatives than of performatives: its felicity condition is nothing less than the narrative entire.

The consequence is formal before it is ethical. By naming its end in advance, the film dissolves suspense, the governing affect of the revenge plot, and replaces it with something closer to liturgy. One does not watch to learn *whether* Bill will die, any more than a congregant attends Mass to learn whether the host will be consecrated; one watches for the exactitude of a performance whose outcome is fixed and whose efficacy resides in form. This substitution of liturgy for suspense is the first datum from which the argument departs.

The Polysemy of a Name

The name that the imperative targets is overdetermined to a degree that rewards philological patience. A *bill* is an invoice, the written form of a debt. To "kill a bill," in American legislative idiom, is to defeat a proposed law before its enactment. A *bill* is the beak of a raptor. And "Bill" is the hypocorism of William, from the Germanic *Wilhelm*, compounded of *willo*, will, and *helm*, protection.

Each sense opens a philosophical register that the film activates: the debt, which Nietzsche identified as the archaic matrix of guilt (*Schuld*, from *Schulden*); the law, and the sovereign who suspends it; the predator; and the paternal will, the primal father whose murder, in Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913), founds the very law it violates. At the level of its title alone, *Kill Bill* enjoins its heroine to cancel a debt, abort a law, slay a predator, and overthrow a will. The question pursued here is which of these injunctions the film fulfils, and at what cost.

The epigraph compounds the difficulty. The "old Klingon proverb" on the coldness of revenge is borrowed from a 1982 science-fiction sequel, *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*, and ascribed to a fictional civilization; the proverb's European pedigree is itself obscure and frequently, though dubiously, credited to Laclos. The film thus opens by confessing that its wisdom is secondhand and partly fabricated, an "invented tradition" in Hobsbawm and Ranger's sense, and then treats that borrowed wisdom with scriptural gravity. Invented tradition performed as efficacious rite: this paradox is the hinge on which the argument turns.

The State of the Question

Critical reception has largely moved within three paradigms. The first, descended from Fredric Jameson, reads the film as the apotheosis of postmodern pastiche, a "blank parody" that mimics dead styles without satirical impulse or historical depth. The paradigm correctly identifies citation as structural, but it cannot account for the affective gravity of the final chapter, and it presupposes that repetition must empty what it repeats.

The second, articulated most incisively in Lisa Coulthard's "Killing Bill: Rethinking Feminism and Film Violence," reads the heroine's violence as postfeminist: empowerment individualized, aestheticized, and finally recontained by maternity. The paradigm correctly identifies the maternal closure, but it treats maternity solely as containment and misses the philosophical wager the film places on birth.

The third, indebted to Edward Said, reads the film's Japan and China as Orientalist décor through which a white heroine acquires mastery. The paradigm correctly perceives the racial distribution of death, but it underestimates how thoroughly the film's "Eastern" sources were already hybrid, transnational, and themselves Western-facing. Each paradigm sees one face of the film and mistakes it for the whole. The present study does not refute them so much as subsume them: pastiche, postfeminist recontainment, and Orientalist appropriation are real features of *Kill Bill*, but they are moments within a ritual structure that none of them describes.

Method

The method is that of philosophical film criticism in the line of Stanley Cavell, for whom film is a medium that thinks, and of Stephen Mulhall, for whom certain films do not illustrate philosophy but philosophize. It is joined to a comparative intellectual history that recognizes two registers of origin. The first comprises documented sources: the films, manga, songs, and tales that Tarantino cites, adapts, or acknowledges. The second comprises structural homologies: philosophical positions that the film's situations instantiate without demonstrable influence, assembled, in Benjamin's sense, into a constellation that renders the film legible.

Throughout, documented debt is distinguished from probable allusion, and both from hermeneutic homology, which is flagged explicitly as such. Ritual anthropology, in the work of Arnold van Gennep, Victor Turner, and above all Ernesto de Martino, supplies the synthetic frame.

Thesis

The central claim is that *Kill Bill* is a *tarantic rite of natal vengeance*. Six concepts organize the demonstration. *Natal vengeance* names a vengeance whose terminus is not equivalence but the clearing of a space for beginning: violence subordinated to natality. The *tarantic rite*, after de Martino's analysis of Apulian tarantism, names a form that re-stages an originary bite through coded music, color, and choreography in order to resolve a crisis of presence, without abolishing the bite's periodic return.

Re-presencing names the process by which a subject annulled (comatose, nameless, buried) recovers presence, name, and the capacity to act. The *talionic remainder* names what the rite cannot discharge. The *Nikki Bell Principle* names the structural law by which vengeance that orphans a child bequeaths a vendetta. And *natal humanism* names the humanism toward which the film gestures and which it cannot fully reach: a humanism grounded in the fact of birth and the capacity to begin rather than in a fixed human essence.

Architecture

The argument unfolds in five parts. Part One (Chapters 1–2) reconstructs the film's East Asian and Occidental genealogies. Part Two (Chapters 3–5) analyzes its ethics of vengeance: the arithmetic of talion, the revolt against time, and the passage from mythic to divine violence. Part Three (Chapters 6–7) treats the metaphysics of the subject: Bill's doctrine of innate killerhood and the film's politics of nomination. Part Four (Chapters 8–9) addresses the body, the gaze, and the racialized ledger of the dead. Part Five (Chapters 10–11) assembles the synthesis: *Kill Bill* as tarantic rite, and natal humanism as its unfinished horizon.

Note on Texts

The two volumes are treated as one work in ten chapters, a unity confirmed by the combined cut, *Kill Bill: The Whole Bloody Affair*. Chapters are cited by number and title. Dialogue is paraphrased save for a few brief quotations. Japanese is romanized in modified Hepburn, Chinese in pinyin, save where a Cantonese form is established in the martial-arts literature.

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PART ONE

I

Genealogies

CHAPTER ONE

Children of the Asura

CHAPTER TWO

The Occidental Ledger and the Tarantinian Archive

CHAPTER ONE

01

Children of the Asura

East Asian Genealogies of the Avenging Woman

The film's deepest source is not a single film but a Buddhist cosmology transmitted through a manga: the asura realm of perpetual war, from which Lady Snowblood takes her name and from which Kill Bill *seeks, without fully finding, an exit.*

IN THIS CHAPTER

1.1 Shura-dō: Lady Snowblood and the Child as Weapon
1.2 Koike's Double Inheritance: The Baby Cart and the Bed
1.3 Onryō and Urami: The Revenant Wife
1.4 Nüxia: From Nie Yinniang to Golden Swallow
1.5 The White Eyebrow and the Nun
1.6 Jingi Naki: Fukasaku and the Asura Realm in Confucian Translation
1.7 Bushidō as Invented Tradition, and the Sword That Cuts God

1.1

Shura-dō: Lady Snowblood and the Child as Weapon

Toshiya Fujita's *Lady Snowblood* (*Shurayuki-hime*, 1973), adapted from the manga of Kazuo Koike and Kazuo Kamimura, is the film's master source. Its chaptered architecture and intertitles shape the whole of *Kill Bill*; its snow-bound final duel and its theme song, Meiko Kaji's "Shura no Hana" ("The Flower of Carnage"), migrate into the fifth chapter. Yet the debt is not merely stylistic. Four criminals murder the husband and son of Sayo, Yuki's mother, and the three men among them rape her; imprisoned for life after stabbing to death the one who has taken her to Tokyo as his concubine, she deliberately conceives a child in prison to complete a vengeance she will not live to finish. The child is born an instrument. Her name, "Princess Snow of the Asura," locates her in *shura-dō*, the realm of the asuras in Buddhist cosmology: jealous, warlike demigods condemned to perpetual conflict, one of the six destinies of rebirth.

Kill Bill inverts this matrix with precision. In Fujita's film maternity serves vengeance: the child is engendered as a weapon. In Tarantino's, vengeance serves, and is finally dissolved by, maternity: the weapon becomes a mother. The inversion is the film's first philosophical act. In Buddhist cosmology only the human realm, neither the heavens nor the realm of the asuras, affords the conditions for awakening; to leave *shura-dō* is to be reborn human. Read through this cosmology, the trajectory of Beatrix Kiddo is a migration between destinies, from the asura realm of the Deadly Viper Assassination Squad to the human realm of a motel bathroom where a mother weeps. Whether the migration succeeds is the question of this dissertation's final chapter.

1.2

Koike's Double Inheritance: The Baby Cart and the Bed

Koike's other great revenge epic, *Lone Wolf and Cub* (*Kozure Ōkami*, illustrated by Goseki Kojima), supplies the complementary paternal model: the disgraced executioner Ogami Ittō, his wife murdered, wanders Tokugawa Japan as an assassin, pushing his infant son Daigorō in a weaponized baby cart. Its American recut, *Shogun Assassin* (1980), narrated in voiceover by the child, is the film Beatrix and B.B. watch together in bed on the last night of *Kill Bill*.

The citation is a gesture of extraordinary density. The canonical image of patrilineal vengeance (a father, a son, a road of corpses) is inserted into the closing frame as a bedtime story: domesticated, miniaturized, and handed down. The patrilineal source is not refuted; it is inherited by a daughter. That inheritance, Chapter 11 will argue, is the film's most unsettling remainder.

1.3

Onryō and Urami: The Revenant Wife

A second Japanese lineage runs through the theater and folklore of the vengeful ghost. In Tsuruya Nanboku IV's *Tōkaidō Yotsuya Kaidan* (1825), the wife Oiwa, poisoned and disfigured with her husband's connivance, dies and returns as an *onryō*, a spirit of grievance, to destroy him. Her motive is *urami*, the grudge that survives death; and Meiko Kaji's "Urami-bushi," the song of resentment from Shunya Itō's *Female Convict Scorpion* series, accompanies the end credits of the second volume.

Beatrix is structurally an *onryō*: a woman left for dead by the man to whom she was bound, who returns from the edge of death, twice, from a coma and from a grave, to collect what is owed. Slavoj Žižek's Lacanian account of the living dead, who return because a symbolic debt remains unpaid and a rite of passage was botched, describes her exactly; Chapter 7 returns to it.

1.4

Nüxia: From Nie Yinniang to Golden Swallow

The Chinese genealogy is older still. In Pei Xing's ninth-century *chuanqi* tale "Nie Yinniang," which Hou Hsiao-hsien filmed in 2015 as *The Assassin*, a general's daughter is abducted by a Buddhist nun and trained as an assassin. Sent to kill an official, she delays, because she finds him playing with his small son; her mistress rebukes her and instructs her, in future, to kill the beloved first. Eleven centuries before Beatrix declines to kill Vernita Green in front of her daughter, the founding text of the female knight-errant (*nüxia*) stages an assassin's hesitation before a parent in the presence of a child. The motif of the child as the point at which killing falters is the oldest stratum of the film's ethics, and it is Chinese.

The *nüxia* passed into cinema through King Hu, whose *Come Drink with Me* (1966) made Cheng Pei-pei's Golden Swallow the model of the sword-fighting heroine, and whose *A Touch of Zen* (1971) joined martial choreography to Chan Buddhist transcendence. Against this female-centered wuxia, Chang Cheh's *One-Armed Swordsman* (1967) inaugurated the cult of *yanggang*, staunch masculinity, with its brotherhoods, mutilations, and martyr's deaths. *Kill Bill* reabsorbs *yanggang* into female bodies: Chang Cheh's signature amputation is inflicted by one woman on another, Beatrix cutting off both of Sofie Fatale's arms, and the heroic martyr-death is replaced by survival.

1.5

The White Eyebrow and the Nun

Lau Kar-leung's *The 36th Chamber of Shaolin* (1978) founded the pedagogical subgenre whose ordeals (carrying water, striking from impossible distances, eating under constraint) structure "The Cruel Tutelage of Pai Mei." The casting compresses the genealogy into a single body. Gordon Liu, the novice-hero of *36th Chamber*, plays both Johnny Mo, captain of the Crazy 88, and Pai Mei himself, so that Shaolin's most famous pupil returns as its cruelest master.

Pai Mei (Cantonese *Bak Mei*, "White Eyebrow") is drawn from Southern Chinese martial legend, in which he is one of the Five Elders who survived the burning of the Shaolin temple and, in most tellings, the traitor who betrayed it to the Qing. Lau Kar-leung's *Executioners from Shaolin* (1977) cast him, in the person of Lo Lieh, as a villain. Among the same Five Elders stands Ng Mui, the Buddhist nun who, in the origin legend of Wing Chun, taught a young woman, Yim Wing-chun, to fight so that she might defeat a local bully seeking to force her into marriage.

Kill Bill's training sequence is the Wing Chun myth refracted through its villain: a woman schooled in combat because of a coerced bond to a man, taught not by the compassionate nun but by the misogynist traitor. Tarantino substitutes Bak Mei for Ng Mui. The substitution matters, because the traitor's pedagogy will nonetheless transmit to the woman the one technique he withheld from Bill.

1.6

Jingi Naki: Fukasaku and the Asura Realm in Confucian Translation

Vol. 1 is dedicated to Kinji Fukasaku, whose *Battle Royale* (2000) supplied Chiaki Kuriyama, the film's Gogo Yubari, and whose yakuza epic *Battles Without Honor and Humanity* (*Jingi naki tatakai*, 1973) names, in its title, the moral condition of the film's underworld. O-Ren Ishii enters the House of Blue Leaves to Tomoyasu Hotei's "Battle Without Honor or Humanity," composed for a 2000 film that revived the series title.

The Japanese *jingi*, the yakuza code, is formed from the Confucian cardinal virtues *jin* (Chinese *ren*, humaneness) and *gi* (*yi*, righteousness). *Jingi naki* thus means, with philosophical exactitude, "without humaneness and without righteousness." The soundtrack translates the Buddhist asura realm into Confucian terms: a world in which *ren*, the cardinal virtue of classical East Asian

humanism, has been voided. The humanism this dissertation finds at the film's horizon must be measured against that announced void.

1.7

Bushidō as Invented Tradition, and the Sword That Cuts God

The film's samurai ethic is itself a palimpsest. Hattori Hanzō was a historical retainer of Tokugawa Ieyasu and leader of the Iga warriors; Sonny Chiba had played him on television in *Kage no Gundan* (*Shadow Warriors*), and Tarantino's Hanzo, a retired swordsmith keeping a sushi bar in Okinawa, is the actor's role grown old. The ideology Hanzo embodies, the sword as the warrior's soul, owes as much to Nitobe Inazō's *Bushido: The Soul of Japan* (1900), written in English for Western readers, as to any premodern code. The "Eastern" source is already a Meiji export.

Beneath Nitobe lie the *Hagakure*'s identification of the samurai's way with death; Miyamoto Musashi's *Book of Five Rings* (1645), whose pentad recurs in Death List Five, the Five Point Palm, and the five Vipers; and Musashi's last precepts, the *Dokkōdō*, an ethic of solitary self-possession. Deepest of all lies Chan Buddhism. Hanzo's benediction on the blade, "If on your journey, you should encounter God, God will be cut," and the voiceover epigraph to Chapter Five, which bids the warrior kill whoever obstructs him even if it be God or the Buddha, paraphrase the most notorious saying of Linji Yixuan (d. 866): if you meet the Buddha, kill the Buddha. In Linji the injunction is soteriological. It severs attachment to every idol, including the idol of enlightenment.

The same epigraph, however, instructs the warrior to "suppress all human emotion and compassion." Here the film's explicit warrior code is anti-humanist by design. The argument of this dissertation is that *Kill Bill* performs that code with total conviction for four hours and then, on a bathroom floor, revokes it, and that Linji's sword, which cuts every attachment, finally cuts the attachment to vengeance itself.

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CHAPTER TWO

02

The Occidental Ledger and the Tarantinian Archive

The film's Western sources supply what its Eastern sources lack (the list, the withheld origin, the exploitation body, and the revenge tragedy's divided humanism), while its auteurial archive records, in costume and prop, a history of cross-racial appropriation the film both indexes and repeats.

IN THIS CHAPTER

2.1 The List: Woolrich, Truffaut, and the Bureaucracy of Vengeance
2.2 The Doorway and the Withheld Origin
2.3 The Exploitation Body
2.4 The Revenge Tragedy and the Humanist Objection
2.5 The Tarantinian Archive: Foxes, Flutes, and a Yellow Suit
2.6 Pastiche, Parody, or Rite?

2.1

The List: Woolrich, Truffaut, and the Bureaucracy of Vengeance

Cornell Woolrich's *The Bride Wore Black* (1940), filmed by François Truffaut in 1968, furnishes the plot's skeleton with uncanny exactness: a groom shot dead on the church steps on his wedding day, and a widow-bride who hunts down, one by one, the five men responsible. Tarantino has said he had not seen Truffaut's film before making his own. The disavowal is less interesting than the structural form both works share, which is the list. Julie Kohler's crossing-out of names, like Beatrix's Death List Five, translates vengeance from passion into administration. The list is the modern form of the feud: a ledger, a docket, a schedule of payments. Its arithmetic is the subject of Chapter 3.

2.2

The Doorway and the Withheld Origin

The massacre at Two Pines, withheld until the sixth chapter, is framed through a chapel doorway that quotes the most famous composition in John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956). Ford's film concerns the recovery of a girl raised in a distant household of those her searcher calls enemies, a plot *Vol. 2* repeats when Beatrix finds B.B. in Bill's Mexican hacienda. The withholding itself derives from Sergio Leone's *Once Upon a Time in the West* (1968), whose avenger's motive is disclosed only in a final anamnesis.

The Western genealogy is not, however, an Occidental enclosure. Leone's *A Fistful of Dollars* (1964) remade Kurosawa's *Yojimbo* (1961), which drew on American hard-boiled fiction and on Ford; Tarantino's film, scored in part with music from Italian westerns by Ennio Morricone and Luis Bacalov, closes the circuit by returning the western to Japan. The genealogy is a loop, not a line, and any account of the film's Orientalism must reckon with that circulation.

2.3

The Exploitation Body

Bo Arne Vibenius's *Thriller: A Cruel Picture* (1973), in which a pimp abducts a mute young woman, forcibly addicts her to heroin, prostitutes her, and punishes her resistance by having one of her eyes cut out, until she trains herself into an avenger, supplies Elle Driver's eyepatch and, more consequentially, the trafficking logic of the hospital sequence. Carol Clover's analysis of the rape-revenge film in *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) established that the

genre's female avenger often serves as a vehicle for male spectatorial identification, a body through which masculine fantasies of victimization and retaliation are rehearsed. *Kill Bill* inherits this ambiguity in full; Chapter 8 measures what it does with it.

2.4

The Revenge Tragedy and the Humanist Objection

The European revenge tragedy descends from Seneca, whose *Thyestes* and *Medea* bequeathed to Kyd, Shakespeare, and Middleton the ghost, the delay, the banquet of horrors, and the exultant avenger. The paradox is foundational: the same Seneca, in *De Ira*, anatomized anger as a brief madness and enjoined its extirpation. The tradition is born divided against itself, and *Kill Bill* inherits the division.

Its closest Shakespearean analogue is not *Hamlet* but *Titus Andronicus*, in which Lavinia, raped and mutilated, is deprived of tongue and hands so that she cannot name her assailants. Beatrix, raped while comatose by a hospital orderly and by the men to whom he sold access to her body, answers with the mouth: her first act against another upon waking is to bite.

The definitive humanist objection to the tradition is Francis Bacon's essay "Of Revenge" (1625), which calls revenge "a kind of wild justice" and warns that the man who studies revenge keeps his own wounds green, which otherwise would heal. Bacon's most pointed sentence anticipates the film's central calculation: "In taking revenge, a man is but even with his enemy." The word *even* recurs, as Chapter 3 shows, at the moral center of the film's first chapter.

2.5

The Tarantinian Archive: Foxes, Flutes, and a Yellow Suit

Within Tarantino's own oeuvre, the Deadly Vipers realize a joke from *Pulp Fiction* (1994): Mia Wallace's description of "Fox Force Five," a failed television pilot about a squad of female agents, among them a blonde leader, a Japanese martial artist, a Black demolitions expert, a Frenchwoman, and a knife-fighter. The prototype's racial typology survives into the Squad, and into the casting of Vivica A. Fox as Vernita Green. The character of the Bride is credited as a co-creation of "Q & U," Tarantino and Uma Thurman, conceived during the making of *Pulp Fiction*, a fact of authorship to which Chapter 9 returns.

Two costumes form the film's most freighted palimpsest. Beatrix's yellow jumpsuit reproduces Bruce Lee's in *Game of Death* (1978), and the Crazy 88 wear the domino masks of Kato, Lee's role in *The Green Hornet*. Bill, meanwhile, is played by David Carradine, star of the television series *Kung Fu* (1972–75), widely

though contestably said to have grown from a concept Lee had pitched, and of *Circle of Iron* (1978), the film Lee had developed with James Coburn and Stirling Silliphant as *The Silent Flute*, completed after Lee's death with Carradine in his place, including in the role of a blind flute-player.

Bill's bamboo flute is the trace of that substitution, and his codename, Snake Charmer, makes it the instrument by which venom is commanded. The heroine thus wears the dead Asian star's costume to kill the white actor who inherited his roles. Whether this constitutes restitution or a second appropriation is a question the film poses and cannot settle. Lesser citations complete the archive: Brian De Palma's split screen in the hospital, Bernard Herrmann's whistled theme from *Twisted Nerve* (1968), and Quincy Jones's siren from *Ironside*, which sounds whenever Beatrix's gaze finds an enemy.

2.6

Pastiche, Parody, or Rite?

For Jameson, pastiche is blank parody, the neutral mimicry of a dead language. For Linda Hutcheon, parody is repetition with critical difference. Neither describes what citation does in *Kill Bill*. Kierkegaard's distinction in *Repetition* (1843) is more exact: recollection repeats backward, toward what has been, while genuine repetition is recollected forward and produces the new. Deleuze, in *Difference and Repetition* (1968), radicalized the point: repetition is the generative engine of difference.

This dissertation proposes that *Kill Bill*'s citations function liturgically. The names of the source films, the songs, and the costumes are invoked as the names of saints are invoked in a litany: not to mimic them but to summon their efficacy for a present rite. The relevant model is not the museum but the ritual repertoire. Chapter 10 identifies the rite.

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PART TWO

II

The Ethics of Vengeance

CHAPTER THREE

"About Even"

CHAPTER FOUR

The Will's Ill Will Against Time

CHAPTER FIVE

From Blade to Palm

CHAPTER THREE

03

“About Even”

Talion, Feud, and the Infinite Progression

The film’s first chapter, set in a suburban kitchen, stages in miniature the juridical history of retribution, from collective feud to individual liability, and then, in a single sentence addressed to a child, reverses it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

3.1 The Arithmetic of Equivalence
3.2 Rationality Without Mercy
3.3 The Literal Talion: Elle’s Eye
3.4 The Infinite Progression
3.5 Girard and the Monstrous Double
3.6 The Absent Areopagus
3.7 Debt, Body, Ledger

3.1

The Arithmetic of Equivalence

The Code of Hammurabi (§196) prescribes that a man who destroys the eye of another shall have his own eye destroyed; Exodus (21:23–25) generalizes the principle: life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth. William Ian Miller, in *Eye for an Eye* (2006) and in his study of the Icelandic sagas, *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking* (1990), has shown that the talion is not the savage principle of popular imagination but a technology of valuation. It fixes a price on injury, limits retaliation to an equivalent, and thereby restrains escalation. Revenge in this sense is moral accounting: it requires a ledger, a standard of equivalence, and agreement about who is liable.

In "Chapter One: 2," Beatrix sits in Vernita Green's kitchen and performs the accounting aloud. Her reckoning, paraphrased, runs thus: to be even, she would have to kill Vernita, go upstairs and kill her daughter, then wait for Vernita's husband to come home and kill him as well, and that would be "about even." The computation is impeccable by the standards of feud. The massacre at Two Pines took her fiancé and her wedding party and, as she then believed, her unborn child; equivalence demands Vernita's household. In feuding societies, as Miller documents, liability is collective: the kin-group, not the individual, owes the debt. Beatrix states the feud's arithmetic precisely in order to renounce it, limiting her claim to Vernita alone.

The renunciation reenacts one of the decisive revolutions in the history of law. Deuteronomy (24:16) decrees that fathers shall not be put to death for their children, nor children for their fathers; every one shall die for his own sin. Ezekiel 18 generalizes the doctrine into a theology of individual responsibility. In a Pasadena kitchen, over coffee, the film traverses the distance between Exodus and Deuteronomy: from the debt of the household to the guilt of the person.

3.2

Rationality Without Mercy

When Vernita appeals for leniency, Beatrix answers with the film's most exact self-description: "It's mercy, compassion, and forgiveness I lack. Not rationality." The sentence disaggregates two faculties the humanist tradition had fused. Kant's retributivism, articulated in the *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797), is rationality without mercy. The right of retribution (*ius talionis*) is the sole principle that can determine the quality and quantity of punishment, and even a civil society on the point of dissolving itself must first execute the last murderer in its prisons, lest blood-guilt adhere to the people (6:332–333). Beatrix is, in this precise sense, a

Kantian. But Kant reserves punishment to the juridical state; private vengeance belongs to the state of nature. She is a Kantian without a state.

Aristotle, by contrast, defended anger as a moral perception. In the *Rhetoric* (II.2), anger is a desire, accompanied by pain, for conspicuous revenge for a conspicuous slight, and its anticipated satisfaction is pleasant; in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (IV.5), the man who is not angry at what he should be angry at is thought a fool, and to endure insult is slavish. Amia Srinivasan's "The Aptness of Anger" (2018) extends the Aristotelian line into feminist philosophy. Anger can be apt, fitting to its object, even when it is imprudent, and the demand that the wronged weigh the costs of their anger is itself an "affective injustice." *Kill Bill* never asks Beatrix to be prudent. The refusal is among its most radical features and among its least remarked.

3.3

The Literal Talion: Elle's Eye

The film's most literal talion is exacted not on Beatrix's behalf but on her master's. Pai Mei had plucked out one of Elle Driver's eyes for an insult, a disproportion and the master's excess; Elle repaid him by poisoning his fish heads. When Beatrix learns of the murder in Budd's trailer, she plucks Elle's remaining eye: an eye for an eye in the most literal sense the cinema has produced, exacted as vengeance for the teacher. The scene reenacts, by structural homology, Perseus's theft of the single eye shared by the Graeae, the gray sisters who guard the way to Medusa.

The consequence is decisive for the architecture of the work. Elle, blinded and alive, is the only name on Death List Five who does not die. The list does not close in death but in a remainder.

3.4

The Infinite Progression

Hegel supplies the film's deepest diagnosis. In the *Philosophy of Right* (§§101–103), revenge is just in content, insofar as it is retribution, but unjust in form, because it is the act of a subjective will. Each revenge therefore constitutes a new injury, and the sequence becomes a progression to infinity, inherited without limit from generation to generation. Only punishment, the negation of crime by the universal will, breaks the series.

Vernita dies because she tries to shoot Beatrix through a box of breakfast cereal, and her small daughter Nikki walks in to see her mother's body. Beatrix's address to the child is the hinge of the entire work: "When you grow up, if you still feel raw about it, I'll be waiting." The sentence revokes the Deuteronomic

individualization of guilt just accomplished. It recognizes the child's future claim as legitimate, offers Beatrix herself as its object, and thereby re-founds the feud across generations, exactly as Hegel predicted.

This structure is what I call the *Nikki Bell Principle*: every vengeance that orphans a child bequeaths a vendetta. O-Ren Ishii, who at nine watched the yakuza boss Matsumoto and his men murder her parents and at eleven killed him, is the principle's past. Nikki is its future. Chapter 11 will show that B.B. is its concealed present.

3.5

Girard and the Monstrous Double

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) explains why the progression cannot halt of itself. Revenge is mimetic: each act imitates the act it answers, and the antagonists come to resemble one another until they become "monstrous doubles." The judicial system, for Girard, does not abolish vengeance but monopolizes it, reserving to a sovereign authority the last word in reprisal.

The film's monstrous double is Elle: blonde like Beatrix, Pai Mei's pupil like Beatrix, Bill's intimate like Beatrix, and possessor, by purchase, of a Hattori Hanzo sword like Beatrix. Their fight in a trailer is the mimetic crisis in its purest form. Beatrix ends it not by sacrifice, for the double is not killed, but by blinding. The double can no longer see, and therefore can no longer imitate.

3.6

The Absent Areopagus

Aeschylus's *Oresteia* is the founding myth of the passage from blood vengeance to law. Clytemnestra kills Agamemnon, who had sacrificed their daughter Iphigenia; Orestes kills Clytemnestra; the Furies pursue him; and Athena founds the Areopagus, which acquits him and converts the Furies into the Eumenides, the "kindly ones," guardians of the city. The acquittal rests on Apollo's notorious argument (*Eumenides*, ll. 658 ff.) that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed the father sows. Western law, in its founding drama, is constituted by the denial of maternal kinship.

Kill Bill rewrites the cycle from Clytemnestra's side. Beatrix avenges a child she believes killed by its father. The child lives, as Iphigenia lives in Euripides' *Iphigenia among the Taurians*, spirited from the altar to a distant land whose custom is to sacrifice strangers, and the mother arrives to reclaim her. There is no Athena and no Areopagus. The only representative of the law is the Texas lawman Earl McGraw, who pronounces the bloodied bride dead and receives, for his error, her blood spat in his face.

Catharine MacKinnon's thesis in *Toward a Feminist Theory of the State* (1989), that the state is male in its point of view, finds here its parodic illustration: the law sees a female body, misrecognizes its life, and is spat upon. Beatrix remains an Erinys never converted into a Eumenid. The film's closing intertitle, which restores the cub to the lioness, is an anti-*Eumenides*: maternal kinship affirmed over the father's corpse.

3.7

Debt, Body, Ledger

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morals* (II §§4–8) derived guilt (*Schuld*) from debt (*Schulden*) and located the origin of punishment in the creditor's right to the debtor's body, the archaic license to cut flesh in proportion to what is owed. When Beatrix, amid the carnage of the House of Blue Leaves, tells the surviving Crazy 88 that they may take their lives with them but must leave their severed limbs, which now belong to her, she asserts precisely the creditor's lien on the body.

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) and Marshall Sahlins's category of "negative reciprocity" in *Stone Age Economics* (1972) situate this lien within a general economy of exchange in which vengeance is the countergift of injury. Death List Five is a ledger; *Kill Bill* is the cancellation of an invoice. The remaining chapters ask whether the cancellation is payment or remission.

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CHAPTER FOUR

04

The Will's Ill Will Against Time

The film's non-linear form is not a postmodern game but an ethics of time: a technique by which the will, unable to undo what was, reorders it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

4.1 Revenge as the Will's Revulsion Against "It Was"
4.2 Améry's Counter-Argument
4.3 The Stolen Years
4.4 Non-Linearity as an Ethics of Time
4.5 Recollection and Repetition
4.6 Amor Fati on a Bathroom Floor?

4.1

Revenge as the Will's Revulsion Against "It Was"

In "On Redemption," in the second part of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Nietzsche defines revenge with a precision unequaled in the tradition: it is "the will's ill will against time and its 'it was.'" The will cannot will backward; the past is the stone it cannot roll. Revenge is the will's resentment of this impotence, displaced onto whatever can be made to suffer. Redemption, conversely, would transform every "it was" into "thus I willed it."

In "On the Tarantulas," Nietzsche gives the spirit of revenge an emblem, the tarantula, whose bite infects the soul with vengefulness disguised as justice. The emblem's etymological kinship with the director's surname is bracketed here and taken up in Chapter 10. Heidegger, in *What Is Called Thinking?* (1951–52), radicalized Nietzsche's insight into a thesis about metaphysics as such: the spirit of revenge is the will's revulsion against time's passing away, and Western thought's flight from transience into permanence is its sublimated form.

4.2

Améry's Counter-Argument

Against Nietzsche, Jean Améry's essay "Resentments," in *At the Mind's Limits* (1966), mounts the most serious defense of the victim's refusal of time ever written. Améry, a survivor of torture, rejected the counsel that time heals. Natural time, which closes wounds biologically, is morally obscene when it absolves the deed. The victim's resentment is the demand that the perpetrator be nailed to his deed, so that he too might wish it undone: a moral turning-back of time in which perpetrator and victim would meet in a shared negation of the past.

The incommensurability between Améry's historical experience and a genre fiction must be stated plainly, and only the formal structure of his argument is borrowed here. That structure, however, illuminates the film. Bill's sole confession, that he "overreacted," is the perpetrator's minimization par excellence: it concedes the deed while reclassifying it as a lapse of proportion. Beatrix's vengeance is Améry's resentment armed, the refusal to let four years of coma heal what the massacre inflicted.

4.3

The Stolen Years

The coma is the film's central temporal fact, and it is easily misread as an ellipsis. Its duration, four years, is the age of B.B. when her mother finds her. The time stolen from Beatrix is not empty; it is the time of her daughter's life, the time of natality itself, appropriated by the man who raised the child while the mother lay unconscious. What Beatrix avenges, without knowing it until the last chapter, is not only a massacre but a confiscated motherhood.

Julia Kristeva's "Women's Time" (1979) distinguishes the linear time of history and project from cyclical time (repetition, gestation, the rhythms of the body) and monumental time (the eternal, the mythic). The revenge plot is linear and teleological: a list, worked through in order. The pregnancy is cyclical: a gestation that continues beneath the plot, unseen. The coma is monumental: a suspension in which the body persists outside history. *Kill Bill*'s form braids the three, and its non-linearity is the visible trace of their friction.

4.4

Non-Linearity as an Ethics of Time

The chapters are shuffled. The second kill precedes the first; the massacre that motivates everything appears halfway through; the pregnancy that motivated Beatrix's flight is revealed only in the final chapter. The conventional reading treats this as Tarantino's signature play with structure. A stronger reading is available. If revenge is the will's ill will against "it was," then the reordering of the past is the cinematic form of that ill will. The film cannot undo the massacre, but it can refuse its chronology, deny the past its precedence, and place effect before cause. Non-linearity is the will's technique for willing backward: a formal revenge on time that accompanies the narrative revenge on persons.

Umberto Eco's "The Myth of Superman" (1962; English 1972) illuminates the stakes from Bill's side. Eco argued that Superman's narratives must unfold in an oneiric, iterative time in which nothing irreversible happens, because irreversibility would consume the hero and bring him toward death. Bill, the film's theorist of Superman, inhabits this mythic time. He is, in his own self-conception, what he always was and always will be. Beatrix, pregnant, comatose, scarred, and aging, is a creature of irreversible time. Their confrontation is a confrontation between mythic and historical temporality, and historical temporality wins.

4.5

Recollection and Repetition

Kierkegaard's distinction returns here with ethical force. The film's citations are recollections; they repeat backward, toward the genre archive. Its rite is repetition in the strict sense, recollected forward toward what has not yet been. The decisive difference lies in what each produces. Recollection produces nostalgia; repetition produces the new. What *Kill Bill*'s repetition produces is a child who is, for the spectator as for her mother, entirely new: the one figure in the film who cites nothing.

4.6

Amor Fati on a Bathroom Floor?

Does the film achieve Nietzschean redemption? Its final image, Beatrix on a motel bathroom floor laughing and sobbing and repeating her thanks, invites the reading. Yet she cannot will the massacre; she cannot say "thus I willed it" of Two Pines. What she achieves is not affirmation of the past but gratitude for what survived it. The distinction is decisive. Gratitude is not the transfiguration of "it was" but the reception of a gift that "it was" did not destroy, and Chapter 11 develops its consequences.

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CHAPTER FIVE

05

From Blade to Palm

Mythic Violence, Divine Violence, and the Life-Giving Sword

One of the most sanguinary films of its decade ends with a bloodless death; the passage from sword to open hand is the passage, in Benjamin's terms, from mythic to divine violence, and in Yagyū Munenori's, from the death-dealing sword to the life-giving sword.

IN THIS CHAPTER

5.1 Benjamin's Distinction
5.2 The House of Blue Leaves as Mythic Violence
5.3 Hanzo's Vow and the Two Swords
5.4 The Palm
5.5 A Herpetology of Violence
5.6 Arendt Against Fanon, and Derrida Against Everyone

5.1

Benjamin's Distinction

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguishes two forms of mythic violence, law-making and law-preserving, from a third, divine violence, which destroys law rather than founding or conserving it. Mythic violence is bloody, it threatens, and it binds the living in guilt. Its emblem is Niobe, the mother whose children are slaughtered by the gods for her boast and who is left alive, petrified in grief, as a boundary-stone of their new law.

Divine violence is expiatory rather than guilt-binding; it strikes rather than threatens; and it is "lethal without spilling blood." Benjamin's culminating formula distinguishes the two by their beneficiary. Mythic violence is power over mere life for its own sake; divine violence is power over all life "for the sake of the living."

5.2

The House of Blue Leaves as Mythic Violence

"Showdown at House of Blue Leaves" is mythic violence in Benjamin's exact sense. Its arterial geysers descend from the chanbara tradition, from the single-stroke spray that ends Kurosawa's *Sanjuro* (1962) to the fountains of *Lone Wolf and Cub*. Its chromatic ruptures, the shift to black and white and the blue silhouette ballet, were reportedly occasioned by the American rating system, the Japanese release preserving the color. Censorship thus became stylization: the body's blood withdrawn from view and replaced by pure figure.

The violence is also law-making in the literal sense. Beatrix issues decrees: the survivors may keep their lives but forfeit their limbs. She grants exemptions, spanking the youngest of the Crazy 88 with the flat of her sword and sending him home to his mother. O-Ren had earlier made law by decapitation. Having beheaded Boss Tanaka at the council table for disparaging her Chinese and American heritage, she declared that every subject might be raised before her save that one. Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception is enacted literally at her table. The House of Blue Leaves is a war of sovereigns.

5.3

Hanzo's Vow and the Two Swords

Yagyū Munenori's *Heihō Kadensho* (1632), the treatise of the Tokugawa sword-instructor, distinguishes the *setsuninto*, the death-dealing sword, from the *katsuninken*, the life-giving sword. When the evil of one person torments myriads, to kill that one is to give life to the many, and the blade that kills becomes the sword that gives life. Hattori Hanzo's vow, sworn decades earlier, never again to make an instrument for killing people, presupposes the first category; his decision to break it presupposes the second.

His justification is pedagogical. Bill was once his student, and the teacher bears responsibility for what the student became. Hanzo forges the sword not to perpetuate killing but to correct a failed transmission, a gesture closer to the Confucian ethics of the teacher than to bushidō's cult of death.

Takuan Sōhō, Munenori's Zen interlocutor, taught in the letters collected as *The Unfettered Mind* that the swordsman's mind must abide nowhere: not on the opponent's blade, not on his own intention, not on victory. Linji's injunction to kill the Buddha belongs to the same soteriology of non-attachment. Read through Takuan, the sword that "cuts God" is a sword that cuts attachment as such, and the final attachment it must cut, if the logic is followed to its end, is attachment to vengeance itself.

5.4

The Palm

That is why the sword does not deliver the final death. At Bill's table, the duel is fought seated. Beatrix catches Bill's blade in her scabbard, the *saya*, the sheath, for which the Latin word is *vagina*, and the feminine sheath disarms the paternal sword. She then strikes him with the Five Point Palm Exploding Heart Technique: five pressure points, five steps, then death. The technique was taught by Pai Mei, who despised women, to Beatrix and never to Bill. The master's highest secret detours around the son and passes to the daughter. Asked why she never told him, she ascribes her silence, with devastating simplicity, to her own badness.

The death that follows is the antithesis of the massacre. The massacre at Two Pines had pitted four armed killers and their commander against an unarmed, pregnant bride and her wedding party. Montaigne, in "Cowardice, the Mother of Cruelty" (*Essays* II.27), argued that valor is content to vanquish its enemy, while cowardice, unable to trust its victory, must annihilate. Two Pines was cowardice in Montaigne's sense.

Bill's death is its opposite. There is no blood. Bill is granted time, five steps, the duration of a composed farewell, and asks how he looks. "You look ready," she

answers. Socrates was granted the interval of the hemlock; the samurai, the ceremony of his own death; Bill is granted recognition. The empty hand (*karate*, in which *kara*, "empty," also writes the Buddhist void) kills without spilling blood. Benjamin's formula is fulfilled to the letter: lethal without bloodshed, expiatory rather than law-founding, and undertaken for the sake of the living child asleep in the next room.

5.5

A *Herpetology of Violence*

The film's own taxonomy encodes the passage. The Deadly Viper Assassination Squad bears the names of snakes, and the herpetology repays attention. Copperhead, cottonmouth, and sidewinder are pit vipers whose venoms act chiefly on blood and tissue. The black mamba is not a viper at all but an elapid, whose venom is predominantly neurotoxic: it kills by paralysis rather than hemorrhage. Its name refers not to its body, which is olive or gray, but to the inky lining of its mouth, displayed when it strikes. No venomous species bears Elle's codename; its nearest referent, the California mountain kingsnake, is harmless, a mimic of the venomous coral snake. Table 1 assembles the ledger.

TABLE 1. THE DEADLY VIPER ASSASSINATION SQUAD: CODENAMES, REFERENTS, FATES

MEMBER	CODENAME	REFERENT AND VENOM	FATE	AGENT
Beatrix Kiddo	Black Mamba	Elapid, not a viper; chiefly neurotoxic; named for its black mouth	Survives; reunited with her daughter	—
O-Ren Ishii	Cottonmouth	Pit viper; chiefly hemotoxic	Scalped by the sword in a snowbound garden	Beatrix
Vernita Green	Copperhead	Pit viper; chiefly hemotoxic	Killed by a thrown knife before her daughter	Beatrix
Budd	Sidewinder	Pit viper (a rattlesnake); chiefly hemotoxic	Killed by a live black mamba hidden in a case of money	Elle
Elle Driver	California Mountain Snake	No venomous species; nearest referent a harmless kingsnake that mimics the coral snake	Blinded and left alive	Beatrix
Bill	Snake Charmer	Not a snake; the charmer's flute commands venom	Killed bloodlessly by the Five Point Palm	Beatrix

The vipers kill and die by blood; the mamba ends the cycle by paralysis and by the empty hand. Beatrix's coma was itself a neurotoxic suspension, a paralysis without death. The heroine's codename thus anticipates the form of her final act: the passage from hemotoxic to neurotoxic violence is the herpetological figure of the passage from mythic to divine violence. And Elle, the mimic, who kills with a

borrowed mamba and so turns Beatrix's codename into a literal weapon, usurps a name whose venom she does not possess.

5.6

Arendt Against Fanon, and Derrida Against Everyone

Frantz Fanon's "Concerning Violence," the opening chapter of *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961), argued that for the colonized, violence is a cleansing force that frees the individual from inferiority, despair, and inaction; Sartre's preface made the thesis lapidary. Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) answered that violence is instrumental and mute: it can destroy power, but it is utterly incapable of creating it.

Kill Bill divides the difference with instructive exactness. Beatrix's violence destroys Bill's sovereignty; it does not create B.B., who was born while her mother lay unconscious. Natality precedes the violence and exceeds it. Violence here clears a space; it does not fill it. That is the meaning of *natal vengeance*: vengeance as clearing, not creation.

A caution is owed. In "Force of Law" (1990), Derrida showed that Benjamin's distinction is undecidable in practice. No one can know, at the moment of its occurrence, whether a given violence is divine or mythic, and the claim to divine violence is the oldest alibi of terror. The present reading must therefore be held as interpretation, not vindication. The film shows a passage; it does not certify that the passage is just.

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PART THREE

III

The Metaphysics of the Subject

CHAPTER SIX

Born or Made?

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Rectification of Names

CHAPTER SIX

06

Born or Made?

The Superman Doctrine and Its Refutations

Bill's monologue on Superman is the film's explicit metaphysics, a doctrine of innate killerhood, and the film tests it, confirms it in one case, and finally exceeds it with an image of the subject as beginning.

IN THIS CHAPTER

6.1 The Doctrine and Its Sources
6.2 Bill as False Nietzschean
6.3 One Becomes
6.4 Xunzi's Board and the House of Blue Leaves
6.5 Chapter One as Experiment
6.6 The Zoological Relapse

6.1

The Doctrine and Its Sources

On the last night, Bill expounds a theory of comic-book mythology. Most superheroes, he observes, are ordinary people who don costumes; Superman alone was born Superman, and his costume is Clark Kent: weak, unsure of himself, cowardly, a figure that amounts to Superman's critique of the human race. Beatrix, he concludes, is likewise a natural-born killer. Her life in El Paso, the used-record store, the fiancé, the domesticity, was her Clark Kent, a disguise worn by a killer bee attempting to pass among worker bees.

The doctrine has a precise lineage. Its central inversion, that Clark Kent is the mask and Superman the face, was articulated by Jules Feiffer in *The Great Comic Book Heroes* (1965), for whom the bumbling reporter was Superman's verdict on the rest of us. Behind Feiffer stands the character's own origin. Jerry Siegel and Joe Shuster's first "Super-Man," in their 1933 story "The Reign of the Super-Man," was a bald, telepathic villain, and the name descended, through George Bernard Shaw's *Man and Superman* (1903), from the standard English rendering of Nietzsche's *Übermensch*. Bill's speech conflates the comic-book hero with the philosophical overman. The conflation is the key to its refutation.

6.2

Bill as False Nietzschean

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morals* (I §13) contains his most celebrated attack on the metaphysics of substance. Popular thought separates the lightning from its flash and posits a doer behind the deed; but there is no "being" behind doing, effecting, becoming; the doer is a fiction added to the deed, and the deed is everything. Bill's doctrine commits precisely the error Nietzsche diagnosed: it posits a killer-substance behind the killing, an essence persisting beneath every costume. Bill speaks in the idiom of the Übermensch while thinking in the metaphysics Nietzsche demolished.

Judith Butler built *Gender Trouble* (1990) on this very passage: gender is performative, and there is no gendered identity behind its expressions. Butler's theory is the feminist completion of Nietzsche's critique, and it refutes Bill on his own philosophical ground. Beatrix, who simply acts, is the truer Nietzschean.

6.3

One Becomes

Simone de Beauvoir's sentence opening the second volume of *The Second Sex* (1949), "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman," inverts Bill's formula exactly. Where Bill says one is born a killer, Beauvoir says one becomes what one is made to be, and can therefore become otherwise. Sartre's *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) generalized the principle: existence precedes essence, and the coward is not born cowardly but makes himself so, and can make himself otherwise.

Behind both stands Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486), in which God tells Adam that he has been given no fixed seat and no form of his own, so that he may fashion himself in whatever shape he prefers. Pico's chameleon-Adam is the humanist anti-Bill, a creature whose essence is its lack of essence. Beatrix, who becomes Arlene in El Paso and then the Bride, the Mamba, and the mother in turn, is the chameleon in a yellow suit.

6.4

Xunzi's Board and the House of Blue Leaves

The deepest refutation comes from classical Chinese philosophy, and it complicates the opposition between born and made. Mencius held that human nature is good, its goodness present in four "sprouts," the first of which is the alarm and compassion anyone feels on seeing a child about to fall into a well (*Mengzi* 2A6). Xunzi replied that human nature is bad and that goodness is the product of deliberate effort (*wei*), artifice, and ritual. His central image is carpentry: a warped board must be laid against the press-frame, steamed, and forced before it becomes straight (*Xunzi*, ch. 23).

"The Cruel Tutelage of Pai Mei" is a Xunzian pedagogy in the most literal sense. Beatrix's ordeal consists in striking a wooden board from three inches until she can punch through it; the board, in Xunzi, is the self that must be straightened by discipline. Her skill is not innate. It is made, by humiliation and repetition, against her body's resistance. Bill's essentialism is refuted by his own genealogy: he too was Pai Mei's student and Hanzo's, and what he calls nature is the residue of training.

Xunzi's first chapter, "An Exhortation to Learning," opens with the maxim that blue dye comes from the indigo plant yet is bluer than the indigo: the student surpasses the teacher. The maxim describes Beatrix's relation to Bill, whose master's ultimate technique she possesses and he does not. That the film's great battle unfolds in a House of Blue Leaves is a serendipity no evidence connects to intention. It is nonetheless the most exact emblem the film offers of its own

argument: the house of blue leaves is the house of the student who has become bluer than the indigo.

Mencius has his share too. B.B.'s account to her mother of how she stepped on her goldfish, Emilio, killing him, and was sorry, displays the first sprout in its purest form: the child's spontaneous recognition that killing is grievous and irreversible. The sprout appears in the daughter of two professional killers. Mencius and Xunzi together answer Bill: capacity may be given, but character is cultivated, and conscience can appear where no one has taught it.

6.5

Chapter One as Experiment

The film does not merely state the doctrine; it tests it, and the test precedes the theory. Vernita Green, who has become Jeannie Bell, a suburban mother married to a doctor, keeps a pistol in a box of breakfast cereal and uses it. Her domesticity was a disguise; her killer's capacity persisted beneath it. The film places this confirmation of Bill's doctrine first in its chapter order and the doctrine's articulation last, so that the spectator receives the evidence before the hypothesis. The non-linear structure is, in this respect, an argument: the doctrine is shown true of Vernita before it is asserted of Beatrix.

The film then distinguishes what the evidence shows from what Bill claims. Vernita's case shows that the capacity for killing persists; it does not show that identity is determined by it. Beatrix nowhere disowns her capacity. She insists instead on what she chose: when the pregnancy test turned positive, she chose for her child against her trade. The film's answer to the Superman doctrine is neither Bill's "born" nor Beauvoir's "made," but Arendt's *begun*: the capacity to initiate something not contained in what one was.

6.6

The Zoological Relapse

The film's metaphors nonetheless pull toward nature. Its assassins are snakes; its final intertitle declares that the lioness has rejoined her cub and all is right in the jungle. I call this the film's *zoological relapse*: the reversion, at the moment of closure, to the naturalism its argument had overcome. Yet the zoology is unstable. As Table 1 shows, the black mamba is neither black nor a viper, the kingsnake is a mimic, and the snake charmer's flute commands what it does not understand. The film's nature is not a realm of essences but a code of mimicry and misnaming. Even its relapse into nature is a relapse into signs.

CHAPTER SEVEN

07

The Rectification of Names

The film withholds its heroine's name for half its length and supplies five substitutes; its narrative is, in Confucian terms, a rectification of names, and the rectification remains unfinished.

IN THIS CHAPTER

7.1 The Bleep
7.2 Liminality and the Unknown Woman
7.3 The Kiddo Problem
7.4 Beatrix and Machiavelli
7.5 Zhengming
7.6 The Lonely Grave of Paula Schultz
7.7 The Ventriloquized Origin
7.8 B.B.

7.1

The Bleep

Throughout *Vol. 1*, whenever a character speaks the heroine's name, the soundtrack bleeps it out, and wherever it appears in writing it is obscured. The device is usually read as playful withholding. It is better read as a sovereign act: the film exercises over its heroine the power of erasure that Bill exercised at Two Pines, and her name is censored by the very apparatus that tells her story.

She is designated instead by substitutes, each of which records a relation of power. "The Bride" names her by a marital status she never attains. "Black Mamba," the codename assigned within Bill's organization, names her by function. "Arlene Machiavelli," the alias under which she sought to marry, names her flight. "Beatrix Kiddo," finally spoken in the second volume, names her by law. And "Mommy," the last name she receives, names her by her child.

7.2

Liminality and the Unknown Woman

"The Bride" is a liminal designation in Arnold van Gennep's sense. The bride stands between separation from one status and incorporation into another, suspended in the threshold phase of a rite of passage; Victor Turner called such persons "betwixt and between," stripped of the old attributes and not yet invested with the new. The massacre arrests the rite in its liminal phase. Beatrix remains the Bride for the whole film because the incorporation that would have ended her liminality, marriage, was destroyed. When incorporation finally comes, it comes by another rite: not as wife but as mother.

Stanley Cavell's *Contesting Tears* (1996) identified a Hollywood genre, the melodrama of the unknown woman, in which a woman achieves her existence not through marriage, as in the comedy of remarriage, but through its negation, frequently in relation to a child. *Kill Bill* is an unknown-woman melodrama in the body of an action film. Its heroine is literally unknown, her name bleeped; her marriage is negated before it can occur; and her selfhood is consummated in relation to a daughter.

7.3

The Kiddo Problem

Her surname poses a problem the film never addresses and cannot evade. "Kiddo" is a hypocorism, an affectionate diminutive of "kid," and it is the word by which Bill habitually addresses her. Every utterance of her legal name therefore

repeats the paternalistic diminutive of the man she must kill. In Lacanian terms, the Name-of-the-Father inscribes the subject in the symbolic order. Beatrix's name is inscribed in advance by the affect of the paternal figure, his term of endearment coinciding with her identity.

I call this the *Kiddo problem*: the name the heroine must reclaim is already marked by the voice of her antagonist. She cannot become herself by name alone. She must become herself by deed.

7.4

Beatrix and Machiavelli

Her given name is no less dense. *Beatrix* descends from the Latin *viatrix*, "voyager," reshaped by association with *beatus*, "blessed": she who travels, and she who makes blessed. Its most famous bearer, Dante's Beatrice, dies in the *Vita Nuova*, the "new life," and returns in the *Paradiso* as the guide to salvation. Beatrix too "dies" and returns, and the new life toward which she travels is a daughter.

Her alias invokes the theorist of *virtù* and *fortuna*. In the twenty-fifth chapter of *The Prince*, Machiavelli declares that fortune is a woman, and that whoever would master her must beat and coerce her. Hanna Pitkin's *Fortune Is a Woman* (1984) showed how deeply Machiavelli's politics depend on this gendered opposition between masculine *virtù*, from *vir*, man, and feminine *fortuna*.

Beatrix inverts the figure. In her own narration she observes that when fortune smiles on something as violent and ugly as revenge, it seems proof not only that God exists but that one is doing His will. The woman who bears Machiavelli's name possesses *virtù* and finds *fortuna* her ally rather than her adversary. Bernard Williams's problem of moral luck, that moral standing depends on what we do not control, becomes in her mouth a theodicy of revenge.

7.5

Zhengming

Confucius, asked what he would do first if entrusted with government, answered that he would rectify names: when names are not correct, speech does not accord with reality, affairs cannot be accomplished, and punishments miss their mark (*Analects* 13.3). Good order obtains when the ruler is a ruler, the minister a minister, the father a father, and the son a son (*Analects* 12.11).

Kill Bill is a narrative of names out of order. The Bride never becomes a wife. Bill, introduced at the wedding rehearsal as the bride's father, is in truth the father of her child, a fact he learns only from her last words before he shoots her

in the head. When he becomes a father in fact, raising B.B. for four years, he does so as the confiscator of her mother's motherhood. The plot is a rectification. By its end the three have been a family for a single night, the father is dead, and the mother is a mother. The rectification is nonetheless incomplete, as the last sections of this chapter show.

7.6

The Lonely Grave of Paula Schultz

Budd buries Beatrix alive in the grave of another woman, Paula Schultz. The misnamed grave is the culmination of the film's onomastic violence: the heroine is not merely nameless but interred under a stranger's name. Sophocles' Antigone is likewise entombed alive, by Creon, for having honored the dead against the law of the city. Hegel, reading her in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (§475), called womankind the everlasting irony of the community. Lacan, in his seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis, located Antigone "between two deaths," the symbolic and the real.

Beatrix inhabits that zone for most of the film, the coma and the grave its two stations, and she leaves it as Antigone could not: by breaking the coffin from within. Slavoj Žižek's account of the living dead in *Looking Awry* (1991) explains why she returns. The dead come back, he argues, when something has gone wrong with their symbolic rites, when they were not properly buried, and they return to collect an unpaid symbolic debt. Beatrix is that revenant. Interred under the wrong name, she rises to collect a debt whose debtor's name is the title of the film.

7.7

The Ventriloquized Origin

Two further misnamings complicate the rectification. O-Ren Ishii's origin is told as anime, in a medium different from the rest of the film, and it is narrated in Beatrix's voice. The film's most extended biography of a woman of color is thus spoken by her killer. Gayatri Spivak's question, "Can the subaltern speak?" (1988), receives a formal answer here: O-Ren's history is available only in translation, across a change of medium, ventriloquized by the woman who will scalp her. Elle Driver, meanwhile, the mimic of Chapter 5, turns the heroine's codename into a literal weapon, usurping the name as she usurped the place beside Bill.

7.8

B.B.

The child, finally, has no name in the film, only initials. B.B. is a cipher, perhaps the doubled initial of Beatrix and Bill, and she stands at the end where her mother stood at the beginning: designated, but unnamed. The rectification of names is deferred to the next generation.

The one name the film never withholds, from its title to its last chapter, is the father's. *Kill Bill* is spoken in every frame; Beatrix is bleeped. The film's onomastics confirm the thesis of this dissertation. What it accomplishes for its heroine, it accomplishes by deed rather than by name, and what remains unaccomplished is borne by a child.

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PART FOUR

IV

Body, Gaze, and Ledger

CHAPTER EIGHT

Bare Life, the Sold Body, and the Second Birth

CHAPTER NINE

The Gaze and the Ledger of Bodies

CHAPTER EIGHT

08

Bare Life, the Sold Body, and the Second Birth

The hospital sequence is the film's ontological ground zero: a woman reduced to bare life, her body sold, who recovers presence first in a toe and then in the world, and who is born again more than once.

IN THIS CHAPTER

8.1 Bare Life
8.2 The Sold Body
8.3 The Bite
8.4 Re-Presencing
8.5 Three Births

8.1

Bare Life

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of the person who may be killed without the killing counting as homicide: the bearer of bare life, *zoē* stripped of *bios*, life excluded from the political order by the very decision that includes it as exception. The comatose Beatrix is bare life in this precise sense.

Elle Driver, disguised as a nurse, comes to the hospital to kill her with a syringe of poison, and the killing is called off by telephone: Bill judges that to kill her in her sleep would diminish them. His call is a sovereign decision on the exception. He decides that this life may be taken, and decides not to take it. The comatose woman's survival is his prerogative, not her right.

8.2

The Sold Body

Between these sovereign visits, an orderly named Buck rapes her and sells other men access to her unconscious body, at seventy-five dollars a visit, so that they can rape her too. The scene is not graphic, but its logic is total. Kant's Formula of Humanity, which commands that humanity, in one's own person or another's, be treated always as an end and never merely as a means, finds here its paradigmatic violation: a person reduced to a thing, rented by the hour.

Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975), reading Lévi-Strauss's theory of kinship as the exchange of women between men, supplies the structure that unifies the film's economies. Bill's own paternal figure, Esteban Vihaio, whom Beatrix visits in Mexico, is a retired pimp. Bill commands a squad composed largely of women. Buck pimps a comatose body. And at the wedding rehearsal Bill occupies, by Beatrix's own introduction, the position of the bride's father in the exchange that marriage traditionally enacts: the man who gives the bride away. He refuses the exchange, reclaiming rather than relinquishing her.

The massacre at Two Pines is, structurally, a father's veto on the circulation of a woman. Esteban, Bill, and Buck form a single patriarchal genealogy of trafficking, and the film's vengeance runs back along it. The economy reaches into childhood. In the anime origin of Chapter Three, the yakuza boss Matsumoto and his men murder O-Ren's parents while she, aged nine, hides beneath the bed; at eleven she gets close enough to kill him by exploiting his sexual predation on children. Both of the film's avenging women are thus exposed to men through the sexual economy it depicts, the comatose woman sold by the visit and the girl admitted to a predator's bedroom, and both turn that exposure into the means of killing.

8.3

The Bite

Woken by a mosquito, in a reflex of the body before the mind, Beatrix bites the trucker who has paid Buck to rape her as he climbs onto her bed, and kills him; she then kills Buck by slamming a door on his head. Carol Clover's analysis of rape-revenge locates its charge in the transformation of victim into avenger. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) describes the figure of the *femme castratrice* and the myth of the *vagina dentata*, through which patriarchal culture imagines female retaliation.

In *Kill Bill* the retaliatory orifice is the mouth, displaced upward from the site of the rape. The black mamba, recall, is named for the color of the inside of its mouth. Beatrix's first act of vengeance is to bite.

8.4

Re-Presencing

What follows is one of the film's most philosophically serious sequences. Hidden in Buck's truck, Beatrix spends thirteen hours commanding her atrophied body, beginning with the order to "wiggle your big toe." Ernesto de Martino, in *Il mondo magico* (1948), named the condition that magic and ritual exist to address the *crisi della presenza*, the crisis of presence: the threat that the person will lose the capacity to be present in history, to decide, to act, to remain a self before the world. The coma is a total crisis of presence. The thirteen hours in the truck are its first resolution, conducted not by rite but by will: presence reconquered from the extremity inward.

The truck is itself a *détournement* in the Situationist sense theorized by Guy Debord and Gil Wolman. Beatrix drives away in the vehicle emblazoned "Pussy Wagon," appropriating the sign of her violation as the instrument of her liberation. The name of her degradation becomes her means of transport.

8.5

Three Births

Freud, in "The Uncanny" (1919), observed that the fantasy of being buried alive, for many the most uncanny of all, is a transformation of another fantasy that originally had nothing terrifying about it: the fantasy of intrauterine existence. The burial in "The Lonely Grave of Paula Schultz" is therefore, in Freudian terms, a return to the womb. Beatrix's escape, breaking the coffin from within with Pai Mei's three-inch punch and clawing upward through the earth into daylight, is a

birth. She delivers herself. She then walks into a diner and asks for a glass of water.

The emergence also reverses a myth of male origin. Nicole Loraux's *The Children of Athena* (1981) showed how Athenian autochthony, the claim that the first Athenians sprang from the soil, served to imagine civic birth without mothers and to exclude women from the citizen body. Beatrix's emergence from the earth is autochthony reclaimed by a woman: birth from the ground, but of a mother, and by her own hand.

Arendt, in *The Human Condition* (1958), described action and speech as a "second birth," by which we insert ourselves into the human world and take upon ourselves the naked fact of our original appearance. Beatrix is born three times after her first birth: from the coma, from the grave, and, on the motel bathroom floor, into a world that contains her daughter. Each second birth follows a symbolic death, and the film is a sequence of natalities. This is the deepest sense in which its vengeance is natal. Every movement of its violence is followed by a birth, and the last birth it discloses is not hers but her daughter's.

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CHAPTER NINE

09

The Gaze and the Ledger of Bodies

A feminist reading cannot stop at the text; it must ask who looks, whose bodies are spent, and what happened to the body of the woman who played the Bride.

IN THIS CHAPTER

9.1 Visual Pleasure Revisited
9.2 The Body Behind the Image
9.3 Postfeminism and the Master's Tools
9.4 The Ledger of the Dead
9.5 Orientalism and Barthes's Japan
9.6 Recognition

9.1

Visual Pleasure Revisited

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema divides labor between the woman as image and the man as bearer of the look, offering the female body to a male gaze through voyeurism and fetishism. *Kill Bill* confirms and complicates the thesis at once. The camera's sustained attention to the heroine's bare feet, most conspicuously in the hospital and the truck, is a fetishism Tarantino has never disguised, and it functions as an authorial signature.

Yet the film also arms the female look. When Beatrix sees an enemy, the screen flashes red and the *Ironside* siren sounds: her gaze is itself an alarm, a look that triggers violence. Yvonne Tasker's account of the action heroine's "musculinity" in *Spectacular Bodies* (1993), and Jeffrey A. Brown's analysis in *Dangerous Curves* (2011) of the heroine as simultaneously fetish and subject, describe the resulting double coding, which the film never resolves.

Roland Barthes's essay on professional wrestling in *Mythologies* (1957) supplies a further key. Wrestling, Barthes argued, is not a contest but a spectacle of excess in which every gesture is legible, and suffering, defeat, and justice are displayed in pure form. The House of Blue Leaves is wrestling in Barthes's sense: violence as moral semaphore, the body rendered wholly legible. The fetishized body and the legible body coexist, and the film's feminism lives in the tension between them.

9.2

The Body Behind the Image

The film's gender politics are not confined to its images. The Bride is credited as a joint creation of Tarantino and Thurman. In a 2018 interview with Maureen Dowd in *The New York Times*, Thurman described a car crash on the Mexican location of *Vol. 2*: Tarantino persuaded her to drive a car she did not feel safe operating, and the crash left her with a concussion and damaged knees. She obtained the footage only fifteen years later, when Tarantino gave it to her. She also said that Tarantino himself spat in her face in the shot where Budd is shown spitting on her, and choked her with a chain in the shot where Gogo is shown choking her. In the same article she said that Harvey Weinstein, whose company, Miramax, released the film, had tried to force himself on her at the Savoy Hotel in London in the 1990s; Weinstein, through a representative, largely confirmed her account and apologized, while denying that he had ever threatened her. Tarantino denied forcing her into the car, called the crash one of the biggest

regrets of his life, and said the spitting and choking were done with her consent, to make the scenes realistic.

These facts do not falsify the film's feminism, but they relocate it. For two of the assaults the film inflicts on its heroine, the author himself stood in for the characters who commit them, and the sovereign structure the film dramatizes, a man deciding what risks a woman's body will bear, recurred at the scene of production. Whether consent, as Tarantino describes it, dissolves that structure or only relocates it is the film's own question asked of its making. A feminism of the text cannot be separated from a feminism of the set, and any account that celebrates the Bride's sovereignty must reckon with the precarity of the woman who embodied her.

9.3

Postfeminism and the Master's Tools

Lisa Coulthard, and the contributors to Yvonne Tasker and Diane Negra's *Interrogating Postfeminism* (2007), have analyzed the postfeminist structure *Kill Bill* exemplifies: female violence offered as individual empowerment, aestheticized, and recontained by maternity. Hilary Neroni's *The Violent Woman* (2005) argued that such figures expose an anxiety at the core of sexual difference that narrative labors to manage. These readings are correct as far as they go. The film's question, however, is sharper than containment.

Audre Lorde warned that "the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house." Beatrix uses only the master's tools: Bill's training, Pai Mei's technique, Hanzo's sword. She kills the master. She does not dismantle the house; she leaves it, carrying her daughter. Lorde's thesis holds, but it describes the film's horizon rather than its failure. The film knows the house still stands.

Two further touchstones mark the poles of the film's position. Virginia Woolf's *Three Guineas* (1938) linked patriarchy to militarism and proposed a Society of Outsiders who would refuse war; Beatrix is an outsider who fights, and the film never imagines Woolf's refusal. Valerie Solanas's *SCUM Manifesto* (1967), introduced by Avital Ronell under the title "Deviant Payback," represents the extremity of feminist rhetoric at which revenge becomes program. In June 1968 Solanas shot Andy Warhol, critically wounding him, and also shot the art critic Mario Amaya: the point at which the program became an act. *Kill Bill* is neither pacifist nor programmatic. Its vengeance is personal and bounded, and, in its distinction, terminated by a birth rather than by a theory.

Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) argued, against Rousseau, that women's apparent weakness was the product of an education designed to produce it, and urged that girls be exercised in body and

mind alike. Pai Mei's tutelage is a Wollstonecraftian education with the cruelty left in: the demonstration that the female body, trained, is the equal of any. Lorde's "The Uses of Anger" (1981) supplies the affective counterpart: anger, focused with precision, as a source of clarity and energy rather than of destruction alone.

9.4

The Ledger of the Dead

Kimberlé Crenshaw's concept of intersectionality requires that the film's distribution of death be read along the axes of race and gender together. The ledger in Table 1 is unequivocal. Vernita Green, a Black mother, is the first kill the spectator sees, and she dies in front of her child. O-Ren Ishii, Chinese-Japanese-American, dies in a Japanese garden. Gogo Yubari, the schoolgirl bodyguard whose image descends from *Battle Royale*, dies at the House of Blue Leaves. Budd and Bill, white men, die. The one member of the Squad maimed but spared is Elle Driver: white, blonde, the heroine's double.

Whatever its intention, a pattern in which the women of color on the list die and the white woman who most resembles the heroine survives is one an intersectional reading cannot pass over. bell hooks's "The Oppositional Gaze" (1992) theorized the Black female spectator who looks against the grain of films that do not see her. Chapter One reads differently from that position: a Black woman who has made a domestic life is hunted in her own kitchen by a white woman who could not, and the film frames the killing as the righteous opening of its list. Vernita's daughter watches. The racial typology of Fox Force Five persists as the archive's grammar. Gogo's case requires precision. The Bride's narration gives her age as seventeen, and the vignette that introduces her shows an adult businessman in a bar seeking sex with her; she stabs and disembowels him, punning on penetration as she does it. The film thus eroticizes a minor in the very scene in which it punishes the man who desires her, offering the image to the gaze it condemns, and the girl who embodies that image is then killed by the white heroine, who drives a nail-studded chair leg into the side of her head.

9.5

Orientalism and Barthes's Japan

Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978), and the account of techno-Orientalism in David Morley and Kevin Robins's *Spaces of Identity* (1995), frame the charge that the film's East is a set of surfaces through which a white heroine acquires mastery: the sushi bar, the Japanese garden, the Shaolin mountain, the anime interlude,

the yellow suit. The charge has force. Three considerations nevertheless complicate it.

First, the film's Eastern sources are themselves transnational and self-exoticizing: Nitobe's bushidō was written for Westerners, and the Kurosawa–Ford–Leone circuit makes the genre a loop. Second, the film's moral authorities are Asian masters, Hanzo and Pai Mei, and its dedication honors Fukasaku. Third, the film's Japan is openly fictive. Barthes opened *Empire of Signs* (1970) with a disclaimer: without claiming to represent any reality, he would isolate certain features of a faraway place and deliberately form them into a system he would call "Japan." Tarantino's Japan is Barthes's, a system of signs assembled from screens.

The fictiveness mitigates the critique without dissolving it, because a fictive system still distributes death. O-Ren's sovereignty, which beheads racism at the council table, is the film's most explicit anti-racist gesture; yet the narrative requires that the hybrid sovereign die by the white woman's sword to complete the list. Even the word *karate* records a history the film does not tell. Its first character was changed in the 1930s from one meaning "Tang," that is, Chinese, to one meaning "empty": a nationalist inscription of emptiness over origin.

9.6

Recognition

What tempers the ledger is recognition. Dying in the snow, O-Ren apologizes for having ridiculed her opponent, and her last words acknowledge the blade that killed her as a true Hattori Hanzo sword. Bill, granted five steps, asks how he looks and is told that he looks ready. Hegel's struggle for recognition, in which self-consciousness achieves itself by risking death before another, and Axel Honneth's reconstruction of recognition as the moral grammar of social conflict in *The Struggle for Recognition* (1992), illuminate these endings.

The duels end not in mere victory but in mutual acknowledgment. Recognition does not undo the ledger's inequities. It shows that the film's violence aspires to something other than annihilation, an aspiration Part Five takes as its object.

PART FIVE

V

Synthesis

CHAPTER TEN

The Land of Remorse

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Natal Humanism and the Nikki Bell Principle

CHAPTER TEN

10

The Land of Remorse

Kill Bill *as Tarantic Rite*

Ernesto de Martino's anthropology of Apulian tarantism supplies the structure that unifies the film's citations, its violence, and its unfinished ending: Kill Bill *is a rite in which a bitten woman dances out a venom that returns.*

IN THIS CHAPTER

10.1 Tarantism
10.2 The Wager of the Name
10.3 The Venom Economy
10.4 The Interrupted Rite
10.5 Pharmakon and Immunity
10.6 Rimorso: The Bite That Returns
10.7 Against Blank Parody: Pastiche as Liturgy

10.1

Tarantism

In the summer of 1959, de Martino led an interdisciplinary expedition to the Salento peninsula of Apulia to study *tarantismo*, the condition of those, predominantly women, who believed themselves bitten by the *taranta*, a spider, and who were cured by music. The cure, documented in *La terra del rimorso* (1961), was a domestic rite lasting days. Musicians with violin, tambourine, and accordion played until they found the air that "caught" the afflicted, who then danced to exhaustion, responding to colored ribbons and cloths as to the colors of the spider. The cycle culminated in the chapel of Saint Paul at Galatina on the saint's feast at the end of June.

De Martino's thesis was that the spider and its venom were symbolic. Tarantism was a cultural order through which unresolved crises (frustrated eros, grief, subordination, a bad past that refuses to pass) were given form, rhythm, and periodic resolution. The bite returned each summer. The title of his book exploits the double sense of the Italian *rimorso*: remorse, and the re-bite, the bite that bites again.

10.2

The Wager of the Name

The city of Taranto has given its name to the tarantula; to the tarantella, the dance once held to cure its bite; and to the surname Tarantino, "of Taranto." No claim is made here that the director's surname informed his film. The etymological convergence is taken as a hermeneutic wager: an emblem that, once noticed, organizes what the preceding chapters have found. Nietzsche had already made the tarantula the emblem of the spirit of revenge; de Martino made the spider's bite the emblem of a past that returns, and the dance its ritual management. *Kill Bill* stands at their intersection.

10.3

The Venom Economy

The film's world is an economy of venom. Its assassins are snakes; its protagonist bears the name of the most feared of African elapids; a live black mamba kills Budd from a case of money; and the Squad's commander, Snake Charmer, carries a flute. The snake charmer's music commands venom and puts it to work, while the tarantella expels it. Bill's flute is the instrument of domination; the film's soundtrack, a jukebox of borrowed airs, is the instrument of cure.

The homology with tarantism holds point by point. The bitten woman is a bride, struck down in a chapel, as the tarantate gathered in the chapel at Galatina. Her bite induces a crisis of presence so total that it takes the form of coma. The cure proceeds through a sequence of airs, each of which "catches" the afflicted and releases her into choreographed motion. Nancy Sinatra's "Bang Bang (My Baby Shot Me Down)" opens the rite; the *Ironside* siren summons the look; Santa Esmeralda's "Don't Let Me Be Misunderstood" sets the duel in the snow to a dance; and Meiko Kaji's "The Flower of Carnage," carried over from *Lady Snowblood*, mourns its dead.

The colors respond like ribbons: the yellow suit, the red flash, the blue silhouettes, the white snow. The fights, choreographed by Yuen Woo-ping, are danced rather than staged. And the measure of the rite's success is not justice, for no court convenes and no law is restored, but the return of presence: a woman who can act, decide, and remain herself before the world.

Even the opening song's title belongs to the rite's logic. Its "baby" is a lover, and its shot is a betrayal. By the last chapter the word has changed its referent: when Beatrix arrives at the hacienda, B.B. greets her with a toy pistol, and her mother, playing along, falls as if shot. The lover's betrayal that opened the film is answered by a child's game.

10.4

The Interrupted Rite

Van Gennep's tripartite structure clarifies how the tarantic rite completes the wedding it replaces. Separation occurred: Beatrix left Bill, the Squad, and her name. The liminal phase was to end in incorporation through marriage, and the massacre froze it. The entire film is the prolonged liminality of a bride who cannot cross the threshold. The tarantic rite does not restore the wedding; it supplies another incorporation. Beatrix is incorporated not into conjugality but into maternity: not into the order of exchange between men but into the order of natality.

Turner's insight that liminality generates *communitas*, a bond outside structure, finds a brief and moving instance in the hotel room where Beatrix, newly certain of her pregnancy, faces an assassin sent to kill her. Two armed women lower their weapons before a positive test, and the would-be killer withdraws with congratulations. It is the film's purest moment of solidarity between women, and it is founded on a birth that has not yet happened.

10.5

Pharmakon and Immunity

Derrida's reading of the *pharmakon* in "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the Greek word means at once poison and remedy, and that the undecidability is constitutive. Vengeance in *Kill Bill* is a pharmakon: the poison Beatrix was given and the cure she administers.

Roberto Esposito's *Immunitas* (2002) generalizes the logic. Immunization protects life by introducing into it a controlled dose of what threatens it, as antivenom is raised from venom itself. The Deadly Vipers are a *communitas* in Esposito's etymological sense, a community bound by a *munus*, an obligatory gift: here, the gift of killing. Beatrix's flight was an attempt at *immunitas*, exemption from that obligation, and the massacre was the community's sanction on her desertion. Her vengeance is antivenom, venom turned against venom to immunize her daughter's life.

Immunization, however, carries the autoimmune risk Esposito also theorized: the defense reproduces the violence it repels. Beatrix's address to Nikki Bell is the film's autoimmune moment.

10.6

Rimorso: The Bite That Returns

A tarantic rite does not cure once and for all; it manages a crisis whose return is expected. The film's ending is accordingly not a closure but a schedule of returns. Nikki Bell, promised her turn, will grow up. Elle Driver lives, blind, in a trailer with a black mamba. Sofie Fatale lives, both arms cut off by Beatrix, the second during the torture by which she extracted information about the remaining Vipers. B.B. has lost the father who raised her. Tarantino's own repeated musings about a further installment in which a grown Nikki seeks out the Bride confirm, extratextually, what the structure already implies. The film ends in the land of remorse: the zone in which the bite returns.

It ends in remorse in the moral sense too. A heroine who declared that she lacked mercy, compassion, and forgiveness, and whom the warrior code enjoined to suppress all human emotion and compassion, ends on a bathroom floor in tears. *Rimorso* names both. The bite returns as remorse, and the rite that expels the venom readmits the human emotion the venom had suppressed.

10.7

Against Blank Parody: Pastiche as Liturgy

Here the argument rejoins its point of departure. Jameson saw in pastiche a blank parody, mimicry without content. Tarantism shows what such repetition can be when it is ritual. The musicians' airs were not original compositions but a traditional repertoire, and their efficacy lay precisely in their repetition.

Kill Bill's citations are its repertoire. The film assembles a congregation of cinephiles who recognize the airs (Fukasaku, Fujita, Leone, Lee) and, recognizing them, participate in the rite. What appears from outside as blank parody is, from within, liturgy: the invocation of known forms for the sake of a present efficacy. The pastiche is not empty. It is sacramental.

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

11

Natal Humanism and the Nikki Bell Principle

The film's final philosophical claim is that natality, not justice, interrupts the automatism of vengeance; its final contradiction is that the intertitle proclaiming this restores a nature the film had refuted and conceals a remainder the film had named.

IN THIS CHAPTER

11.1 Natality and Irreversibility
11.2 The Positive Test
11.3 Against the Lioness
11.4 The Nikki Bell Principle, Reflexively Applied
11.5 Natal Humanism
11.6 Debt, Jubilee, Gift
11.7 A Feminism of the Second Birth

11.1

Natality and Irreversibility

In *The Human Condition*, Arendt identified two predicaments of action: its irreversibility, since what is done cannot be undone, and its unpredictability, since its consequences cannot be foreseen. The remedy for irreversibility is the faculty of forgiving; the remedy for unpredictability is the faculty of promising. Vengeance, she wrote, is the natural, automatic reaction to transgression, which can be expected and even calculated, whereas forgiveness alone does not merely re-act but acts anew. And the miracle that saves the world from its normal, "natural" ruin is, ultimately, the fact of natality: that new people are born, and with them new beginnings.

Kill Bill contains no forgiveness; its heroine disclaims the faculty explicitly. What it offers instead is natality. The interruption of automatic re-action comes not from a pardon but from a birth. B.B. is the miracle in Arendt's precise sense: an event the chain of vengeance did not produce and cannot contain. The goldfish Emilio is the film's parable of irreversibility, told by a child who knows that she killed something and is sorry. The sprout Mencius found in every heart appears in the one person in the film who was raised by a killer and has never killed anything on purpose.

11.2

The Positive Test

The pregnancy test of the final chapter is the film's Arendtian event. Revealed last, though it caused everything, it interrupts not only Beatrix's career but the logic of the scene in which it is discovered: an assassin arrives, two killers face each other, and a strip of plastic suspends the killing. Pei Xing's Nie Yinniang hesitated before a father playing with his son; Beatrix's adversary hesitates before a mother who has just learned that she is one. Across eleven centuries and two civilizations, the oldest stratum of the film's ethics recurs: the child, actual or anticipated, is the point at which killing falters.

11.3

Against the Lioness

The closing intertitle, "The lioness has rejoined her cub, and all is right in the jungle," must now be read against the film's own argument. Beauvoir warned that maternity, naturalized, confines woman to immanence, to the repetition of species-life, and denies her the transcendence of the project. The intertitle naturalizes exactly what the film had shown to be chosen. Beatrix did not rejoin

her cub by instinct but by a decision made over a pregnancy test and executed across a continent of corpses. It is the zoological relapse in its plainest form.

Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* (1989) offers the corrective. Mothering, for Ruddick, is not a nature but a practice, defined by the work it does (preservative love, nurturance, and training) and open to anyone, of any sex, who takes it up. Ruddick's definition yields the film's most uncomfortable truth. For the four years of B.B.'s life, the person who performed maternal practice was Bill: he fed her, sheltered her, and raised her in his house. By Ruddick's criterion, Beatrix kills the one who had mothered her daughter. The intertitle's "all is right in the jungle" erases four years of care, and the child's loss of the one who gave it.

11.4

The Nikki Bell Principle, Reflexively Applied

Here the principle formulated in Chapter 3 completes its circuit. Beatrix told Nikki Bell that if, grown, she still felt raw about her mother's death, Beatrix would be waiting. By the ethics Beatrix herself articulated, the same promise is owed to B.B. The heroine has done to her own daughter what she did to Vernita's: killed, before the child could understand it, the parent who raised her. Applied reflexively, the Nikki Bell Principle makes B.B. the next O-Ren and the next Nikki.

The film does not say this; its structure does. The intertitle's serenity is ideological closure, falsified by an ethics the film had already spoken aloud.

11.5

Natal Humanism

From these findings the dissertation derives its principal positive concept. *Natal humanism* is a humanism with five features.

It is grounded in the fact of birth and the capacity to begin, not in a fixed human essence; it sides with Pico, Beauvoir, and Sartre against Bill's Superman. It understands the human as a practice rather than a nature: with Xunzi, it holds that what we are is made by cultivation, and with Ruddick, that care is a discipline open to anyone. It orients action toward what Tzvetan Todorov, in *Imperfect Garden* (1998), called the finality of the *you*, the other person as the end of action and never its instrument: against Buck's commerce, and against *Lady Snowblood*'s child conceived as a weapon.

It is articulated across traditions. Its East Asian name is *ren*, which Confucius, asked by Fan Chi, glossed as loving people (*Analects* 12.22), and its first evidence is the Mencian alarm before the child at the well. And, distinctively, it knows its own remainders. Natal humanism does not promise that birth redeems violence.

It holds that birth interrupts violence, and it records, as part of its own content, the children who inherit what was interrupted.

The concept stands in deliberate contrast to the anti-humanist warrior code the film announces, to suppress all human emotion and compassion, and to the *jingi naki* of its yakuza world, without humaneness or righteousness. Against both, the film's last movement restores what they suppressed: emotion, compassion, and the face of a child.

11.6

Debt, Jubilee, Gift

The title's first meaning returns at the end. If *Kill Bill* means "cancel the invoice," the question is whether the debt is paid or remitted. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) reconstructed the deep entanglement of morality with the language of debt and recalled the ancient institution of the Jubilee, in which, according to Leviticus 25, debts were released, bondsmen freed, and every one returned to his family. The film's ending has the shape of a Jubilee: release, freedom, a return to one's family. But a Jubilee is a remission, not a payment, and the film's debt was paid in blood.

Its last utterance belongs cleanly to neither economy. On the bathroom floor, Beatrix repeats her thanks. Nietzsche, in *Human, All Too Human* (I §44), described gratitude as a milder form of revenge: the powerful repay a benefactor's intrusion by intruding in turn. Derrida, in *Given Time* (1991), described the pure gift as that which must not return, which annuls itself the moment it is recognized as a gift and repaid.

Beatrix's gratitude has no addressee. It is not repayment to anyone; it is the reception of what no one gave. In a film structured throughout by exchange (debt, list, payment, lien), it is the single utterance outside the economy. Hélène Cixous's Medusa, beautiful and laughing in "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975), laughs here, and the laughter is mixed with tears.

11.7

A *Feminism of the Second Birth*

What does *Kill Bill* finally offer feminist thought? With Wollstonecraft, the education of a woman's body to full capacity. With Beauvoir and Butler, a subject who becomes through deeds and refutes the doctrine of innate nature. With Kristeva, a form braided from linear, cyclical, and monumental time. With Cixous, laughter at the end of a rite. With Lorde, anger used with precision. With Arendt, a sequence of second births. I call this a *feminism of the second birth*: a feminism

in which a woman annulled by sovereign violence is reborn through her own deeds into a world in which she can act.

What it withholds is equally precise. It withholds solidarity among women, save in one hotel room. It withholds structural critique: the state is absent and justice is private. It withholds racial reckoning: the ledger of the dead is unequal. And it withholds, by its intertitle, the acknowledgment that its heroine has deprived her daughter of the father who raised her. These are not incidental flaws. They are the talionic remainders the rite cannot discharge, and together they constitute, in de Martino's sense, the land of remorse in which the film ends.

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CONCLUSION



Thank You, Thank You, Thank You

Kill Bill *kills the bill but not the debt: it ends in natality rather than justice, and in remorse rather than redemption.*

This dissertation has argued that *Kill Bill* is a tarantic rite of natal vengeance, and that this description subsumes the three paradigms (pastiche, postfeminism, Orientalism) that have governed its reception. The genealogies of Part One converged on two figures: a woman schooled to kill whose killing falters before a child, from Nie Yinniang to the Bride; and a world announced as *jingi naki*, without humaneness or righteousness, the asura realm in Confucian translation.

Part Two showed that the film stages the history of retribution in miniature, from collective feud to individual liability, before re-founding the feud in the Nikki Bell Principle; that its non-linear form is an ethics of time, a technique for willing backward; and that its violence passes from blade to palm, from mythic to divine violence, a passage encoded in the herpetology of its names. Part Three showed that Bill's Superman doctrine is a false Nietzscheanism, refuted less by the feminist counter-thesis that one becomes than by the image of the subject as beginning, and that the rectification of names the film undertakes is deferred to a child known only by initials. Part Four located the film's ontological ground in bare life and its successive second births, and insisted that the body of the actress and the ledger of the dead belong to the film's feminism as fully as its images. Part Five assembled the synthesis: the film as tarantic rite, natal humanism as its horizon.

The dissertation contributes, first, a method: the analysis of citation as liturgy, in which repetition is read for its efficacy rather than its originality. It contributes, second, a set of concepts offered for use beyond this film: natal vengeance, the tarantic rite, re-presencing, the talionic remainder, the Nikki Bell Principle, the zoological relapse, the Kiddo problem, and natal humanism.

Its limits are equally explicit. Several of its most consequential connections (Xunzi's indigo and the House of Blue Leaves, the etymology of the director's surname, the herpetology of the codenames) are hermeneutic wagers rather than demonstrated influences, and they are offered as such. Two lines of further inquiry follow. The first is comparative. The tarantic frame invites study of other ritual orders of vengeance, among them the Corsican *voceri*, the improvised laments in which women mourned the murdered and incited their kin to vendetta, legible through de Martino's general theory of ritual lament in *Morte e pianto rituale* (1958); and the codified blood feud of the Albanian *Kanun*.

The second concerns Tarantino's later work. If *Kill Bill* is the will's ill will against "it was" in a single life, *Inglourious Basterds* (2009), *Django Unchained* (2012), and *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* (2019) extend the same revolt to history itself, rewriting the past so that a dictator dies in a burning cinema, enslavers fall, and a murdered woman lives. *Kill Bill* is the private prototype of a

historical project of counterfactual vengeance, and the ethics of that project awaits its own reckoning.

The film's last image remains its most exact. A woman lies on the floor of a motel bathroom, laughing and sobbing, repeating her thanks to no one. She is no longer in the asura realm. She is in the human one, the only realm, in the Buddhist cosmology from which the film's oldest source takes its name, where awakening is possible. Yet she is in the land of remorse as well. The child in the next room has lost the father who raised her; a girl in Pasadena is growing up; a blind woman in the desert is alive. The bill has been killed; the debt has not. What remains is a child, a promise made to another child, and the bite that will return: which is to say, a world in which, as Arendt insisted, something new can still begin.

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INDEX TERMS

Keywords

Kill Bill · Quentin Tarantino · revenge · lex talionis · blood feud · retributive justice · natality · natal vengeance · natal humanism · second birth · Hannah Arendt · Walter Benjamin · divine violence · mythic violence · Friedrich Nietzsche · ressentiment · Jean Améry · G. W. F. Hegel · Immanuel Kant · René Girard · mimetic violence · *Oresteia* · tarantism · Ernesto de Martino · crisis of presence · rites of passage · liminality · pharmakon · immunitas · debt · gift · jubilee · feminist film theory · postfeminism · the gaze · maternal thinking · performativity · intersectionality · Orientalism · transnational genre cinema · wuxia · nüxia · *Lady Snowblood* · bushidō · Zen Buddhism · Confucianism · *ren* · rectification of names · Xunzi · Mencius · Renaissance humanism · existentialism · bare life · rape-revenge · pastiche · repetition



Set in Lora and Carlito on a 7 × 10 in. page. The seal bears the character ren, *humaneness: the East Asian name this dissertation gives to natal humanism.*





THE LAND OF REMORSE